

The Key in the Red Coat

Book 4 of 10

A second-hand coat. A mysterious key. And a question that changes everything.

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A small English town. A charity shop, a care home, and a library.

Genre: Mystery

Characters

- Anna - 40. Office worker. Practical and organised.
- Val - 55. Librarian. Curious and warm.
- George - 82. Retired. The previous owner of the coat.
- Thomas - 78. George's brother. Lives in Vancouver.

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Anna is in a charity shop on a Saturday morning. She finds a red coat - old but good quality. She tries it on. It fits perfectly. She looks in the mirror. She likes it. She pays three pounds and takes it home. That evening, she puts her hands in the pockets. In the left pocket - something small and cold.

Anna takes it out. It is a key - old, small. Not a door key. Maybe for a box or drawer. It is silver, or was silver once. Now it is grey and a little dirty. There is nothing else. No note. No label. Anna puts the key on the kitchen table. She makes tea. She looks at it. 'Where do you come from?' she says to it.

On Monday, Anna goes back to the shop. 'The red coat I bought - I found a key in the pocket.' The woman looks at it. 'That came in last week. From an old house on Church Street. Number eleven.' 'Do you know who lives there?' 'An old man. He moved to a care home. His daughter brought the clothes.'

After work, Anna walks to Church Street. Number eleven is a tall, narrow Victorian house.

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Anna finds a red coat in a charity shop.

The garden is small. There are roses - brown and dead now, but there were a lot of them. Anna stands at the gate. The windows are dark. No one is home. She does not know the man. She does not know his daughter. But she has his key.

The next day, Anna goes to the library. She is not sure why - she just feels someone there might know. The librarian has warm eyes and reading glasses. 'I am looking for information about number eleven, Church Street.' 'That would be George Hall. He lived there for fifty years. Nice man. Very quiet.' The librarian leans forward. 'Is that his key?'

The librarian's name is Val. 'George came here every Tuesday for thirty years. He read history books.' 'He is still alive - at Maple House, the care home on the High Street. But he is not very well.' Anna shows Val the key again. 'I think this is the key to his writing box. A beautiful old wooden box. He always wrote letters in it.' 'A writing box?' Anna says.

The next Saturday, Anna goes to Maple House. 'I have something that belongs to George Hall.' A nurse takes her to a small room. George is sitting by the window - very old and very thin, but his

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Anna studies the small old key from the coat pocket.

eyes are clear and blue. He looks at Anna. Then at the key in her hand. He does not speak. But something in his face opens - like a door.

Anna puts the key on the small table between them. George picks it up. His hands shake a little. 'Where did you find this?' 'In a red coat. In a charity shop.' 'My daughter sent all the clothes. She did not know about the key.' 'What does it open?' George looks at the window. 'A box,' he says. 'With letters inside. Letters I never sent.'

'I wrote them over forty years. To my brother.' 'We had a fight - a big, stupid fight over money. He moved to Canada. We did not speak for forty years.' 'Did you send any of the letters?' 'No. I always wanted to. But I was afraid. What if he did not want to hear from me?' 'Is he still alive?' George is quiet. 'I don't know,' he says.

That evening, Anna calls Val. 'The letters are in the box. George has a brother in Canada - Thomas Hall. They did not speak for forty years. He does not know if Thomas is alive.' Val is quiet. Then: 'Do you have the brother's name?' 'Thomas Hall.' 'Give me two days.' Two days later, Val calls: 'Thomas Hall. He lives in Vancouver. He is seventy-eight. And he is alive.'

Anna goes back to Church Street. George's daughter Helen is there, clearing the house. Anna explains. Helen finds the writing box in a wardrobe - a beautiful dark-wood box with brass corners. Anna puts the key in the lock. It turns. Inside: forty years of letters. All addressed to Thomas Hall, Vancouver. All unsent. 'What do we do?' Helen asks. 'I think,' Anna says, 'we send them.'

Helen calls George. 'Dad. Anna found the box. What do you want to do?' There is a long silence. 'Send them. No - wait. Send only the last one. It says everything. Let the others stay in the box.' Helen looks at Anna. Anna nods. They find the last letter. It is dated three years ago.

Helen reads the last letter quietly, to herself. Then she gives it to Anna. The letter is short: "Thomas. I am an old man. I think about you every day. I am sorry about the money. It was stupid. You are my brother. I miss you. If you read this - please write back. George." 'This is a good letter,' Anna says. 'Yes,' Helen says. Her eyes are wet.

Helen sends the letter by post with a note: 'Dear Uncle Thomas. I am George's daughter. Dad asked me to send this. He is not well. But he hopes

you will read it.' Three weeks later, a letter arrives at Maple House. The handwriting on the envelope is shaky but clear. It is from Thomas.

A nurse reads the letter to George. Thomas writes: "Dear George. I waited forty years for this letter. I am glad it came. I am not angry - only sad. I thought about you every year. On your birthday. I can come. My granddaughter lives in London. I visit her every summer. I can come in July. Write back. I want to hear your voice. Your brother, Thomas." George is very quiet. Then: 'Tell Helen to say yes.'

Helen calls Anna. 'He wrote back. Thomas is coming in July to see Dad.' Anna is at her kitchen table. She looks at the small silver key. 'That is wonderful,' Anna says. 'None of this would happen without you, Anna. You found the key. You went to Maple House. You talked to Dad.' 'I just found a coat,' Anna says. 'Yes,' Helen says. 'But you did not throw the key away.'

In July, Anna does not see the meeting - it is private. But Helen sends her a photograph. Two old men sitting at a table by a window. George - very thin. Thomas - heavier, with white hair. They are not looking at the camera. They are looking at

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The key leads Anna to a drawer full of memories.

each other. George has something in his hand. Anna looks closely. It is the small silver key.

Helen gives Anna the writing box. 'Dad says: you should have it.' Anna takes it home. Dark wood. Brass corners. It smells of old paper. She opens it. The unsent letters are there. She does not read them. She closes the box. She puts the key on top. She leaves them there.

After this, Anna goes to the charity shop more often - not to buy things, just to look. Just to wonder: what is the story of this object? One Saturday she finds an old camera with the name E. Marsh on it. She picks it up. She turns it over. She puts it back. Then she picks it up again. 'That came in yesterday,' the woman at the counter says. Anna nods. 'I know,' she says. 'I can tell.'

Anna still has the red coat. She wears it in winter. It is warm and good quality. Sometimes when she puts her hand in the left pocket, she still feels something - even though the pocket is empty now. She thinks about George. About Thomas. About forty years of letters in a wooden box. She thinks: sometimes a small thing opens a big door. She buttons the coat. She goes outside. The air is cold and clear. She walks.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. charity shop	ikinci el hayır dükkanı	2. quality	kalite
3. fits	uyuyor	4. mirror	ayna
5. pockets	cepler	6. drawer	çekmece
7. silver	gümüş	8. dirty	kirli
9. label	etiket	10. nothing else	başka bir şey yok
11. moved to	taşındı	12. care home	huzurevi
13. daughter	kız	14. brought in	getirdi
15. last week	geçen hafta	16. Victorian	Viktorya dönemi
17. tidy	düzenli	18. gate	bahçe kapısı
19. windows are dark	pencereler karanlık	20. reading glasses	okuma gözlüğü
21. leans forward	öne eğilir	22. might know	biliyor olabilir
23. interesting	ilginç	24. still alive	hâlâ hayatta
25. High Street	Ana Cadde	26. writing box	yazı kutusu
27. wooden box	ahşap kutu	28. belongs to	... ait
29. corridor	koridor	30. thin	zayıf, ince
31. clear	açık, parlak	32. opens	açılır
33. shakes	titriyor	34. sent all the clothes	tüm kıyafetleri gönderdi

35. never sent	hiç göndermedi	36. between them	aralarında
37. brother	erkek kardeş	38. fight	kavga
39. over money	para yüzünden	40. Canada	Kanada
41. afraid	korkmuş	42. calls	arar (telefon)
43. give me two days	bana iki gün ver	44. Vancouver	Vancouver
45. alive	hayatta	46. clearing	boşaltıyor
47. wardrobe	dolap	48. brass corners	pirinç köşeler
49. addressed to	... adresine yazılmış	50. unsent	gönderilme miş
51. silence	sessizlik	52. the last one	son olan
53. says everything	her şeyi söylüyor	54. dated	tarihli
55. to herself	kendi kendine	56. miss you	seni özlüyorum
57. write back	geri yaz	58. wet	ıslak, yaşlı
59. by post	posta ile	60. note	kısa not
61. handwriting	el yazısı	62. shaky	titrek
63. glad	memnun	64. angry	kızgın
65. birthday	doğum günü	66. granddaughter	torun (kız)
67. voice	ses	68. none of this	bunların hiçbirisi
69. without you	sensiz	70. throw away	atmak, çöpe atmak
71. wonderful	harika	72. private	özel
73. heavier	daha kilolu	74. closely	yakından

75. camera	fotoğraf makinesi	76. should have it	senin olmalı
77. desk	masa	78. old paper	eski kâğıt
79. on top of	üstüne	80. leaves them	bırakır
81. habit	alışkanlık	82. wonder	merak etmek
83. object	nesne	84. turns it over	ters çevirir
85. I can tell	anlayabiliyor um	86. still has	hâlâ var
87. wears	giyer	88. even though	... olsa bile
89. buttons	düğmeler; düğmelemek	90. air	hava

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. charity shop
- A. çekmece
2. drawer
- B. ikinci el dükkan
3. hesitate
- C. el yazısı
4. handwriting
- D. tereddüt etmek
5. silence
- E. hayatta
6. alive
- F. sessizlik
7. unsent
- G. gönderilmemiş
8. private
- H. özel

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

key - coat - unsent - alive - glad - charity

1. Anna finds the key in the pocket of a red _____.
2. She bought the coat at a _____ shop.
3. The box is full of letters that George never sent - they are all _____.
4. Thomas says he is _____ that the letter came.
5. George tells Helen to send only the last letter - it says everything.

6. Anna still feels something in the empty pocket, even though the key is gone.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Anna buys the red coat from a market. ____
2. George moved to a care home. ____
3. George and Thomas had a fight about a woman. ____
4. Val is a librarian. ____
5. Thomas lives in Australia. ____
6. George has the key in the photograph with Thomas. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What does Anna find in the pocket of the red coat?
8. Who is George Hall?
9. Who is Val, and how does she help?
10. Why did George never send the letters?
11. What does the last letter say?
12. How does Thomas reply?
13. What does Helen give Anna at the end?
14. What does Anna do at charity shops after this experience?
15. What does Anna think at the end of the story?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-A 3-D 4-C 5-F 6-E 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. coat 2. charity 3. unsent 4. glad 5. last letter 6. empty pocket

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. F 4. T 5. F 6. T

7. A small silver key.

8. An old man who lived at number eleven, Church Street.

9. Val is the town librarian. She finds Thomas Hall's address in Vancouver.

10. He was afraid Thomas would not want to hear from him.

11. That he is sorry, he misses Thomas, and he wants Thomas to write back.

12. He writes a letter saying he will come to London in July.

13. The writing box with all the unsent letters and the key.

14. She looks at objects and wonders about their stories.

15. Sometimes a small thing can open a big door.